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“The core competence of Coca-Cola is its distribution system and how it serves its largest customers such as McDonald’s”

as part of a conversation post dinner. “The insight came from mango being a dessert in India,” explains Ray. For Coke, it used Durga Puja in West Bengal. Here, Coke Studio Bangla belted out its music with a host of local food at a ticketed event.

“The communication for each of the brands comes down to *idea first*,” says Sukesh Nayak, Chief Creative Officer at Ogilvy, the agency that handles Coca-Cola’s advertising business. To him, the objective has been to create an end-to-end engagement with the consumers; an ad during a world cup match doesn’t do anything incremental. “The stump cam for Thums Up is now a content game as compared to a typical campaign of drinking it in the stadium,” he says. Stump cam refers to a campaign where consumers can access cricket content by scanning a QR code on Thums Up bottles. “Something like a stump cam allows me to own the content, which throws up opportunities with respect to community and influencers,” says Roy. Referencing the *Memu Aagamu* project, his view is that disruptive content will now become an ecosystem for engagement. “Of course, we will need to create multiple properties much beyond the television commercial,” chips in Nayak.



THE BRAND WITH possibly the most potential in the Coca-Cola stable is Maaza; very little can come in the way of it hitting the \$1-billion mark. In the organised juices market, which is upwards of ₹15,000 crore in size as per industry estimates, Maaza is the clear leader. It is sold at different price points (a higher proportion of pulp makes a variant more expensive) and the most affordable version at ₹10 is up against Parle Agro’s Frooti. On the anvil is the relaunch of Maaza Gold, a more premium offering.

But Maaza faces certain challenges beyond its control. “The opportunity is huge, but dealing with supply chain issues is a reality. [In 2021], the mango crop failed and the situation was tough,” says Roy. By any estimate, over half the crop is wasted each year. For the record, Coca-Cola India is the largest buyer of mangoes in India. Narayanan points out that not only is mango the national fruit, but India is also its largest producer. “Mango is the topmost flavour by a distance. Therefore, just building on the fruit’s capabilities from a supply chain perspective and continuously innovating can put Coca-Cola in a very strong position compared to its peers,” he says.

The other challenge area for the company is energy drinks. In October 2017, PepsiCo India had launched Sting, an energy drink from its international portfolio. At ₹50, a 250-ml can of Sting was less than half the price of market leader Red Bull’s can, which came at ₹110. The PET version was even more attractive—₹25 for 250 ml and ₹50 for 500 ml.

The success of Sting has been stunning, giving revenues of over ₹550 crore in 2021 (calendar year) to its bottler and manufacturer Varun Beverages, according to a Motilal Oswal report. In terms of volumes, Sting sold 23 million cases (one case has 24 units) in 2021, which was a surge of around 5.4x from the previous year. In the first half of 2022, it spiked another 2.9x YoY to hit 30 million cases. Across India, the brand sells at over 3 million outlets, of which 0.4 million are exclusively for Sting. There has not been success of this magnitude in the CSD market for a long time.

The worry for Coca-Cola has been Sting taking away Thums Up drinkers in its largest markets—Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Uttar Pradesh. While Coke did put in Thums Up Charged in the past, the cola and energy combination did not quite work. This July, Thums